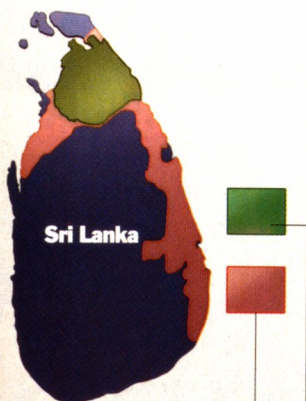


Graphic by RAM



Area freed from LTTE control since 2005

Areas that still remain under LTTE control in 2008

MILITARY BALANCE

LANKAN ARMY: Has a higher ratio of fighting personnel, access to plenty of money and better equipment which has helped it set up deep penetration units.

LTTE: Ageing leaders but highly motivated cadres willing to fight to the finish. But forces and equipment levels down.

FIRE POWER

	LANKA	LTTE
Soldiers	1,55,000	5,000
Tanks	200	-
Artillery guns	1,400	120
Attack aircraft	60	3*
Fast-attack vessels	40	30*

*Modified by LTTE, capability less



PRECISION STRIKES

Precision strikes by air force fighters using bunker-busters and good ground intelligence have helped gun down top LTTE leaders like Tamil Selvam (above) and also damage their infrastructure.

themselves as freedom fighters for Sri Lanka's minority Tamil population. (Tamils form 23 per cent of the 20-million-strong population and LTTE has been waging a 30-year war for a separate homeland for them.) Since then, Fonseka and his 1.6-lakh-strong army have inflicted body blows on LTTE. In less than a year-and-a-half, the army has wrested control of seven districts in the east and the west, which LTTE had previously controlled. The Tigers now have effective control over only two districts—Killinochchi and Mullaitivu—in the north. This is a rump compared to the vast stretches of coastline where their writ once ran.

The armed forces also recently succeeded in killing two of LTTE's top-rung leaders—Tamil Selvam, the political head, and Shanmuganathan Ravishankar alias Charles, the military intelligence chief—in surprise strikes. They narrowly missed striking the feared chief Velupillai Prabhakaran in late December, when the Air Force scored a direct hit on a bunker, known as X-ray, that he frequented. When he didn't make an appearance at Charles's funeral, they suspected Prabhakaran was injured. Subsequently, intelligence believes that he is alive and in full command of his forces.

Fonseka and his army are not willing to allow that position to continue for long. With Sri Lankan President Mahinda Rajapakse formally putting to an end, on January 16, the tattered Cease Fire Agreement (CFA) that a previous government had entered into with LTTE in 2002, the armed forces have stepped up their campaign to tighten the noose they had thrown around the Tiger's last bastion. In a major offensive, Fonseka has lined up five of the 12 divisions of his army to engage Prabhakaran and the LTTE army in a decisive operation to wipe out the organisation. The commander, who announced a policy of killing at least 10 Tiger cadres a day, boasts that of late, he has been able to double that number. With the LTTE army reduced to 3,000-5,000, Fonseka calculates that it can be wiped out in less than a year.

To ensure that he meets the target, Fonseka has brought under siege the dense Wannijungles that act like a natural fortress to the two remaining districts under LTTE's control. He has spent

We are taking territory inch by inch, inflicting casualties. It's only a matter of time before LTTE wilts.

LT-GEN SARATH FONSEKA
ARMY COMMANDER



a good deal of time and money in training and equipping his men to fight like the Tigers. Breaking up his battalions into deep penetration units adept at guerrilla warfare, he has surprised LTTE by the capacity of his army to inflict maximum damage with minimum casualties. To stretch LTTE's defences, he has launched a four-pronged attack coming in from all directions (see chart). While the Tigers engage in conventional warfare by firing mortar, Fonseka's army moves in small bands of killer units, laying booby traps, gathering intelligence and destroying infrastructure like bridges and communication lines. Fonseka, who is not willing to rush in and strike, says, "We are taking the territory inch by inch and foot by foot while inflicting heavy casualties on them. It's only a matter of time before LTTE begins to wilt."

Part of the army's strategy is to step up attacks on all LTTE leaders, with Prabhakaran being on top of the list. As Defence Secretary Gotabaya Rajapakse—the President's younger brother—says, "LTTE, being a monolithic organisation, will collapse if we strike at the head, allowing us to finish it with less casualties and destruction." The younger Rajapakse has been instrumental in transforming the way the Sri Lankan armed forces fought. A former lieutenant-colonel, who fought against the Tigers in the late-'80s and the early-'90s, Gotabaya believes "it is not the weapon but the man behind it that matters most". To make sure he